Reflections on the Crofton formula

Work in progress

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Abstract: The Crofton formula (the length of an arc can be estimated by the number of hits by a random line) is extremely important in modern-day microscopy. Exemplifying Stigler's (1980) law of eponymy (itself actually due to Robert Merton[1]), the formula is more properly described as the Cauchy-Crofton formula (announced in *Comptes Rendus* by Cauchy (1832)), and originates from the famous thought experiment on Buffon's baguettes. Together with the associated Poincaré kinematic formula, Crofton's formula can be proved by a simple intuitive visual argument in the case of polygonal curves. But the Crofton and Poincaré results actually hold for the far more general case of curves of finite total variation, in which context they require rather more technical proofs. I will report on progress I have made in deriving intuitive visual arguments for the general case.

Handout is on the web: use the `QR-code` or visit `wilfridskendall.github.io/talks/CroftonReflections-2026/CroftonReflections-handout.pdf`.

[1] Wikipedia:
"Everything of importance has been said before by somebody who did not discover it", attributed to Alfred North Whitehead.

History (1)

Figure 1: Comte de Buffon

Georges Louis Leclerc (Comte de Buffon, 1707-1788): from a family of minor civil servants, inherited a fortune from godfather, moved to Paris in 1732, researched mathematics and then geology and botany, made a (hereditary) count in 1772, both empiricist ("Anglo-Saxon") and rationalist ("Gallic"). Seeking a motivation for probability other than gambling, Buffon introduced his famous *baguette example* (now "Buffon's needle": see Comte de Buffon, 1829; translation, Hey *et al.*, 2010).

History (2)

Figure 2: Cauchy

Augustin-Louis Cauchy (1789-1857): French mathematician, engineer and physicist. He "is one of the 72 scientists whose name is inscribed on the first floor of the Eiffel Tower". Cauchy (1841; also 1832) used Buffon's ideas to show how to recover the length of a polygonal curve using *projections of the component segments on a random test line*.

History (3)

Figure 3: Crofton

Morgan William Crofton (1826–1915): Anglo-Irish, Anglican Protestant upbringing but converted to Roman Catholism (connected with John Henry Newman), Professor of Mathematics at the Royal Military Academy at Woolwich, famous for his long article on probability in ninth edition of Encyclopaedia Britannica (Crofton, 1902; also Crofton, 1868), including *recovery of length of perimeter of a convex polygon using intersections with a random line*.

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(a) *Stereology:* impose random lattices on image sequence from microscope, count mean number of intersections with filaments of interest, deduce mean length of such a filament;

(b) *Stochastic geometry:* consider mean number of intersections of curve with a *standard Poisson line process*, deduce length of curve;

(c) *Differential geometry:* Chern's kinematic formula (for a very readable account, see Calegari, 2020!).

Crofton's formula: a visual proof

A standard Poisson line process Π in the plane is produced by a unit intensity Poisson point process on $\mathbb{R} \times [0, \pi)$ using intensity measure $\frac{1}{2} \mathrm{d}r \, \mathrm{d}\theta$: here θ is slope and r is the signed distance from origin of the line corresponding to (r, θ). The number of intersections of Π with a unit segment has unit mean (*simple calculation*).

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Let $f{:}[0, L] \to \mathbb{R}^2$ be a polygonal curve, and consider its mean number of intersections with Π. Divide trajectory of f into variable length segments s:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathbb{E}\left[\#\left\{\mathrm{Image}(f) \cap \Pi\right\}\right] &= \sum_s \mathbb{E}\left[\#\left\{s \cap \Pi\right\}\right] \\ &= \sum_s \mathrm{length}(s) \end{aligned}$$

hence Crofton formula:
mean number of intersections with Π *equals length of curve*.

The above proof generalizes to yield *Poincaré's kinematic formula*:

Replace Π by a standard Poisson process of random polygonal fibres.

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Can we generalize further?

Maximal generalization for Crofton formula

The components of Crofton's formula still make sense if $f{:}[0, L] \to \mathbb{R}^2$ is a continuous curve of finite length (Lipschitz(1)). How to prove this?

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- Use the *co-area formula* (Federer, 1969): Consider Lipschitz $p : M \to N$ between (eg) compact C^1 Riemannian manifolds of dimensions $m \geq n$. Then (adjusting exposition of Baddeley, 1983),

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- there is a measurable $J : M \to \mathbb{R}$ such that

$$\int_M f(z) J(z) \mathcal{H}^m(\mathrm{d}z) \quad = \quad \int_N \left(\int_{p^{-1}(x)} f(z) \mathcal{H}^{m-n}(\mathrm{d}z) \right) \mathcal{H}^n(\mathrm{d}x) \,.$$

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Figure 4: Sledge hammer

However, using the co-area formula to prove the Crofton formula itself is rather like using a sledgehammer to crack a nut.

- Ayari & Dubuc (1997) describe how to use the elegant exposition of total variation by Cesari (1958), together with a simple observation by Cauchy (1841; also 1832), which reduces the Crofton formula to the following *one-dimensional* version:

Banach's (1925) representation of total variation

For continuous $f{:}[0,L]\to\mathbb{R}$,

$$\text{Variation}\,(f) \quad = \quad \int_{\mathbb{R}} \#\,\{x\in[0,L]\ :\ f(x)=y\}\ \text{Leb}(\mathrm{d}y)\,, \qquad (1)$$

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- The right-hand side counts the mean number of intersections of the graph of f with a standard Poisson line process of *horizontal* lines (indexed by a unit intensity Poisson point process on the y-axis).

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Objective: obtain a proof of Equation 1 that is as visual as possible.

Initial observation

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1. **Infinite case:** infinite variation is straightforward (polygonal approximation lengths diverge).
2. **Symmetries:** If variation is finite, employ symmetry by
   (i) vertical shifts,
   (ii) non-linear change of x-scale
   to reduce to case in which $f(0) = 0$ and f has weak derivative $\dot{f}$ with $|\dot{f}| = 1$ almost everywhere on $[0, L]$
   (note L now equals total variation of f).

Seeking a visual proof (2)

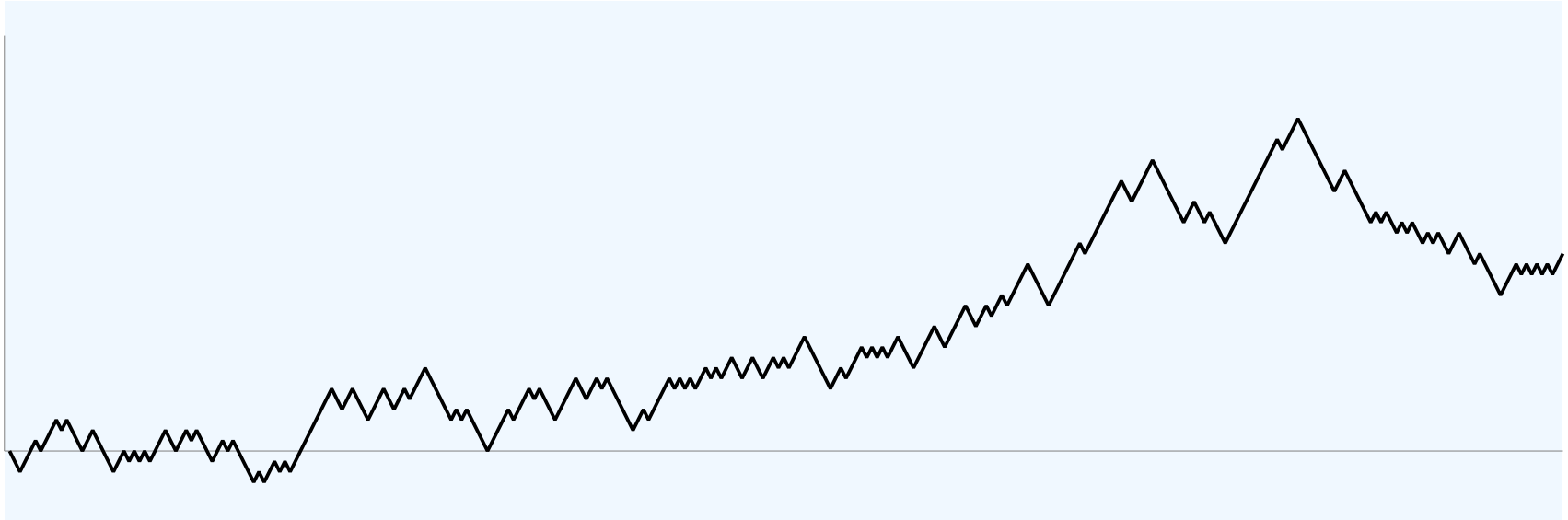

Figure 5: Random walk trajectory

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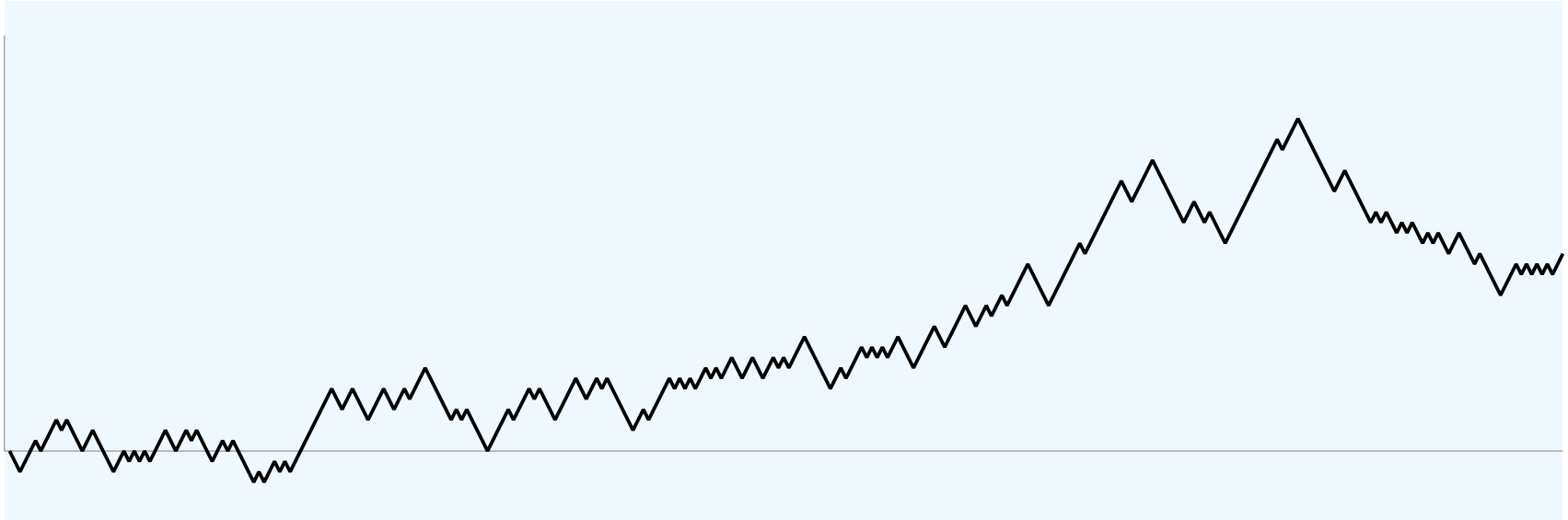

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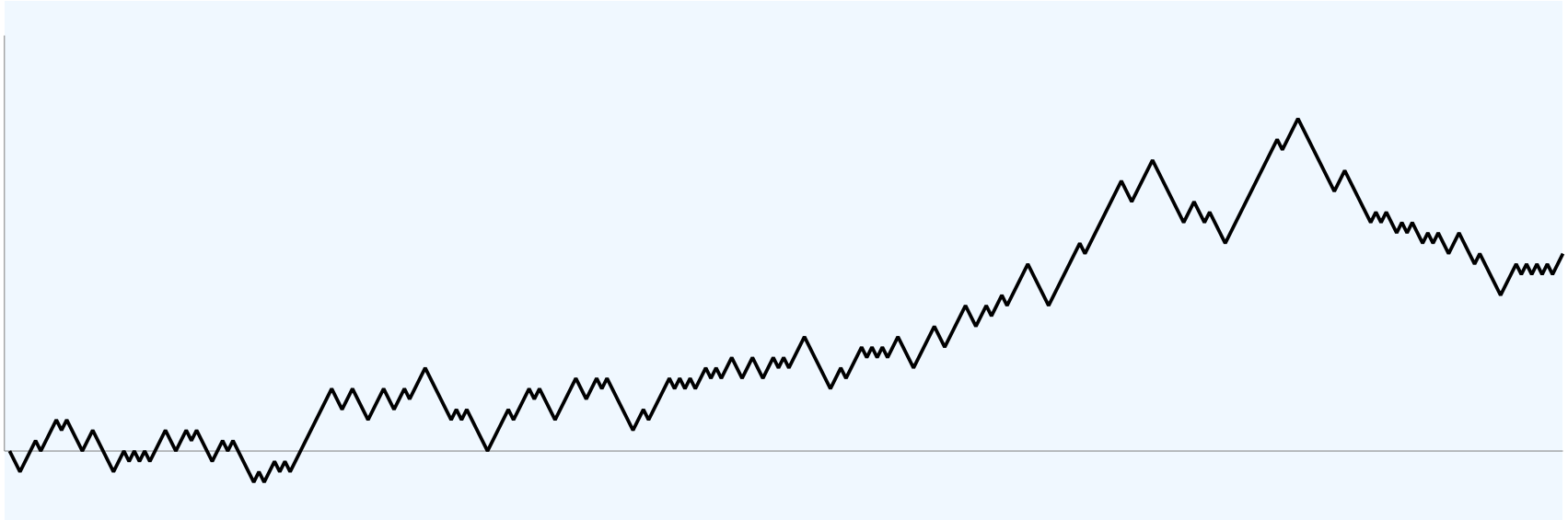

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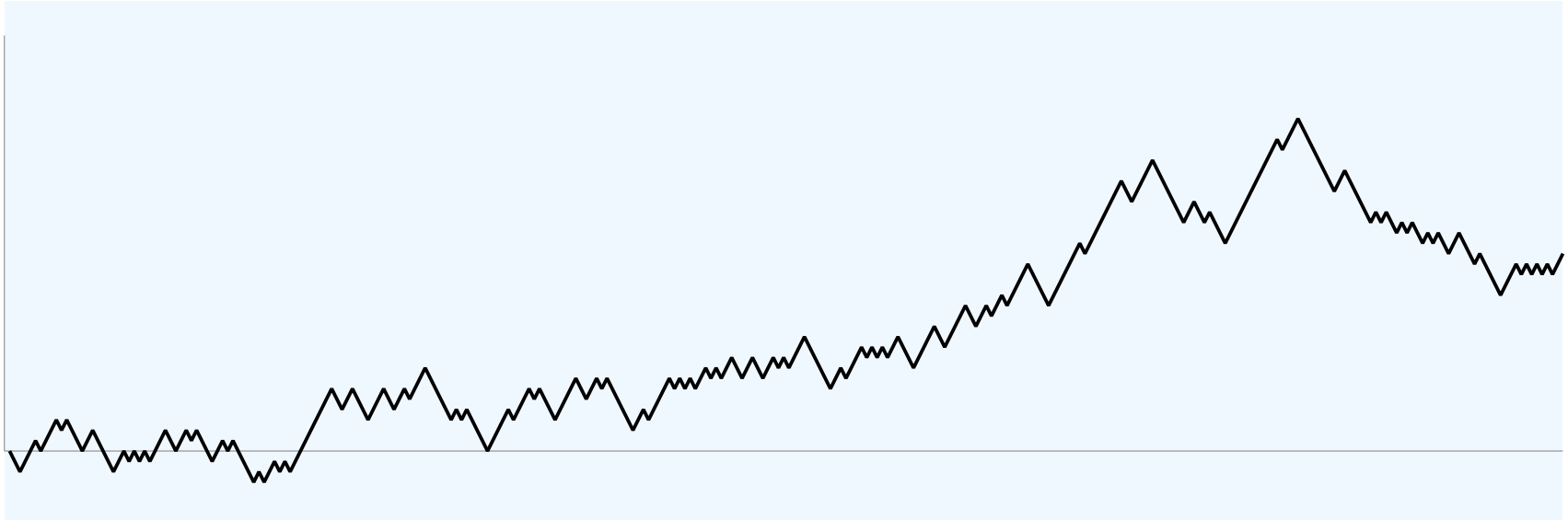

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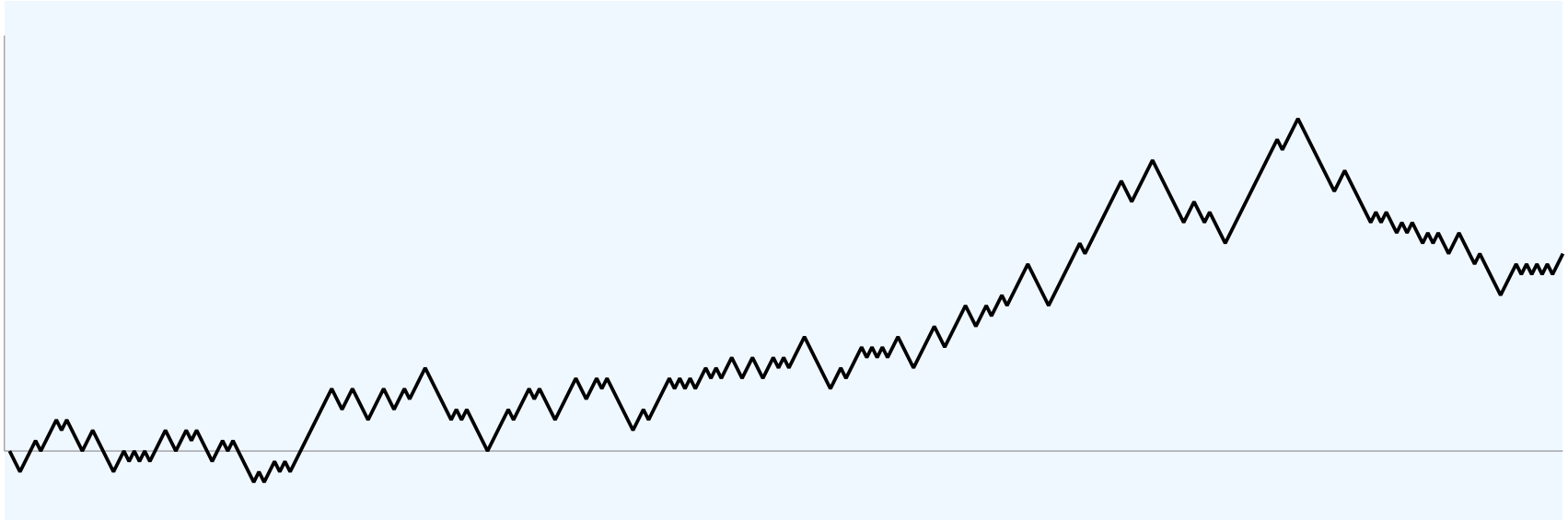

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   (ii) then reflect resulting $\tilde{f}|_{[v,L]}$ in the horizontal line $y=f(v)$.
   - We illustrate this using a random walk trajectory (Figure 5).
   - **Maximal unfold** uses left-most $u<v$ realizing $\sup_{u\leq v}(f(u)-f(v))$.

Seeking a visual proof (3)

0. Original path $f = f_0$ with $u < v$ chosen to yield maximal unfold:

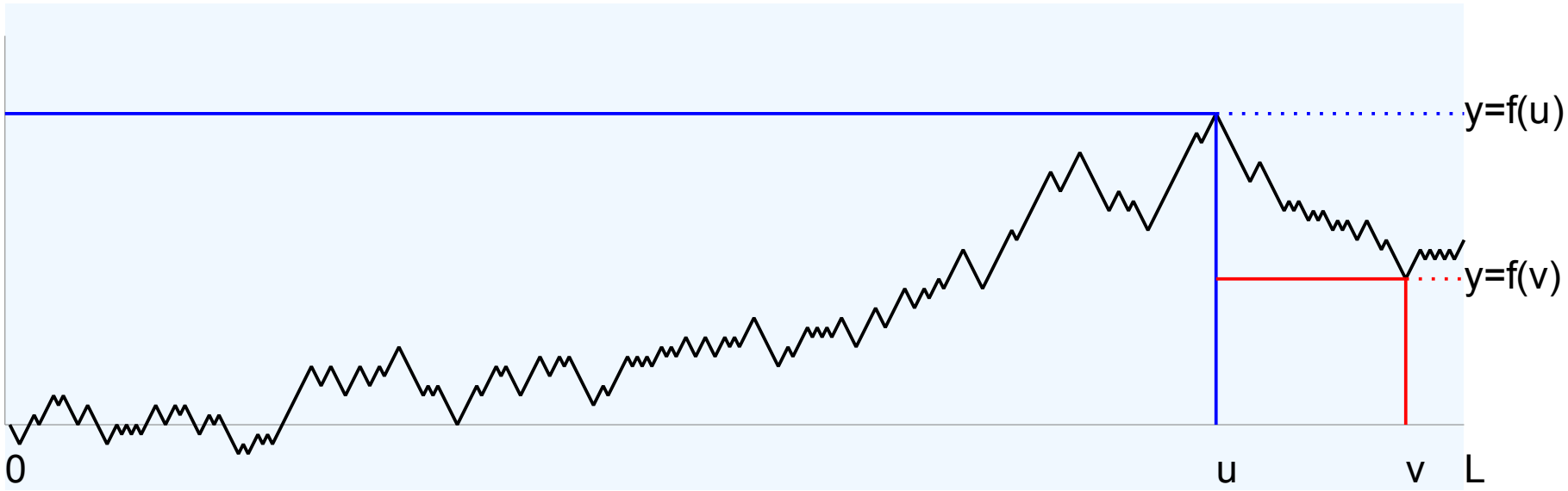


Figure 6: Maximal unfold based at $u < v$

Bear in mind the *size* of the unfold is $2(f(u) - f(v))$.

1. Resulting unfolded path f_1
(note that the *unfolded* path f_1 does not enter the shaded regions):

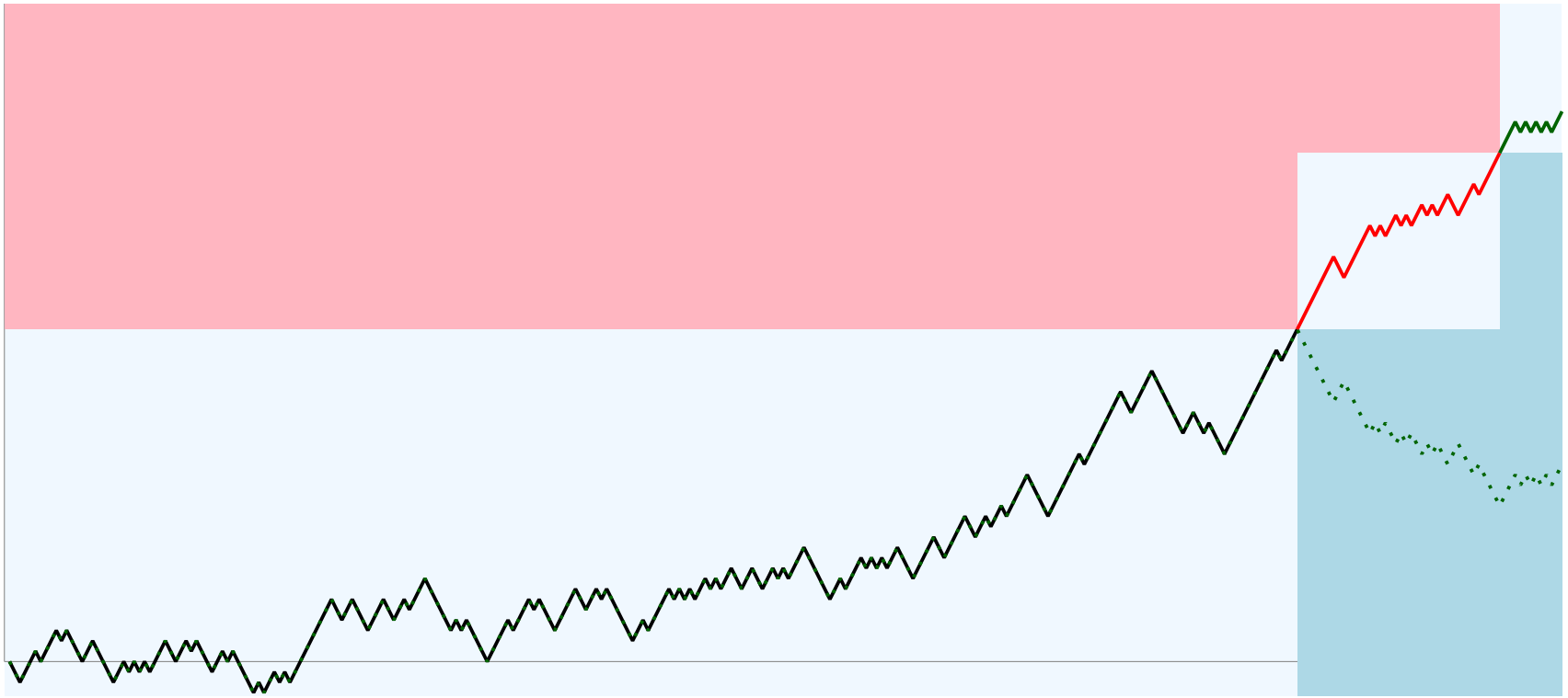


Figure 7: Effect of first unfold

② Second maximal unfolding generates f_2.
The previous shaded region is partially shifted and augmented.

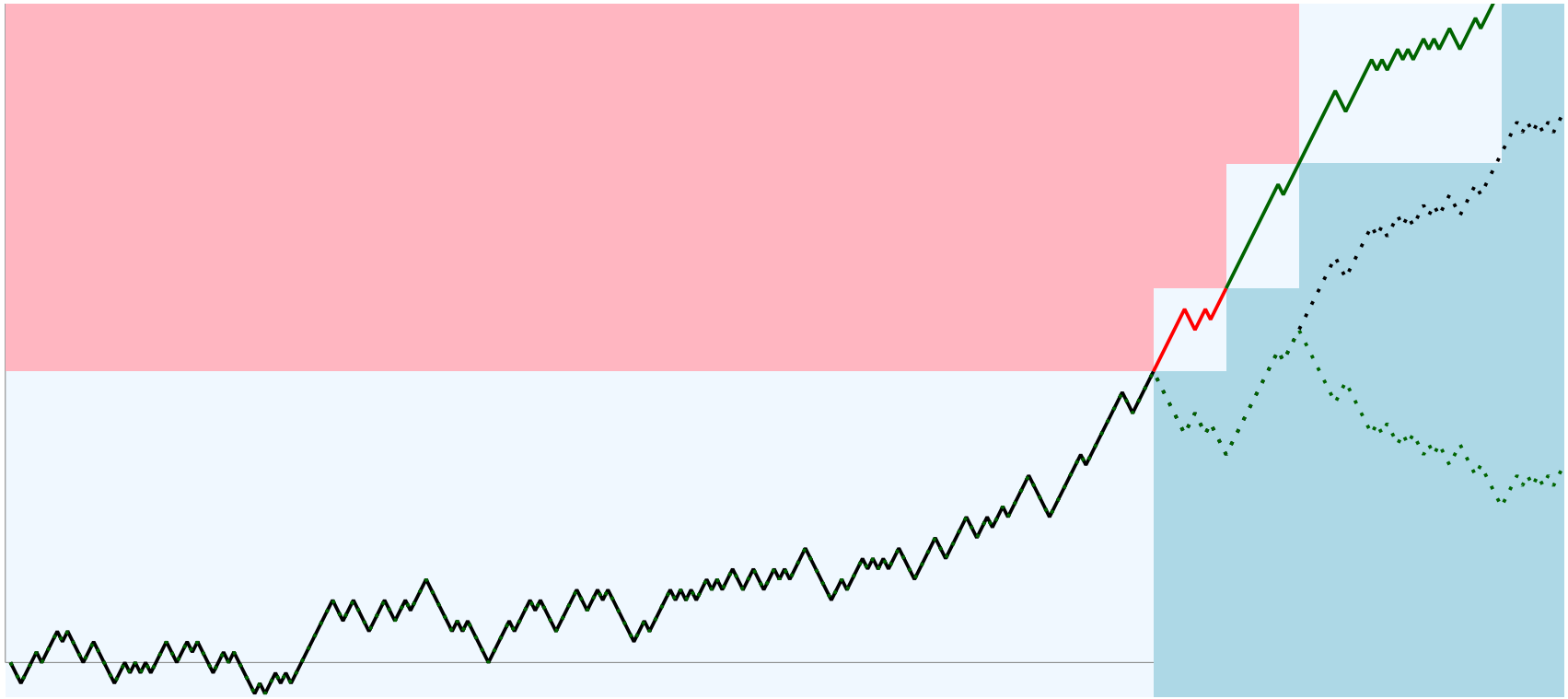


Figure 8: Effect of second unfold

3. Third maximal unfolding generates f_3.
   Again the previous shaded region is partially shifted and augmented.

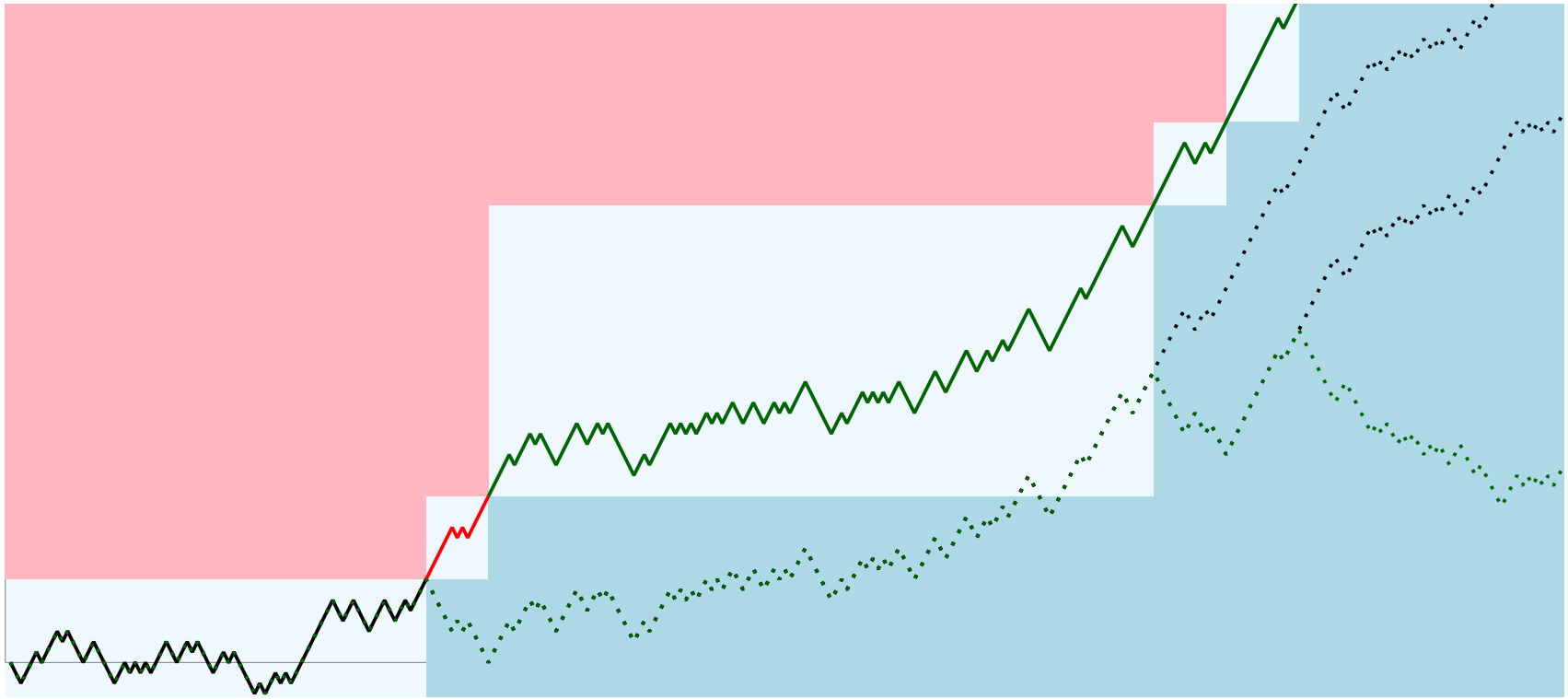


Figure 9: Effect of third unfold

4. Fourth maximal unfolding generates f_4.
The unfolding procedure increases f_n and makes it more monotonic.

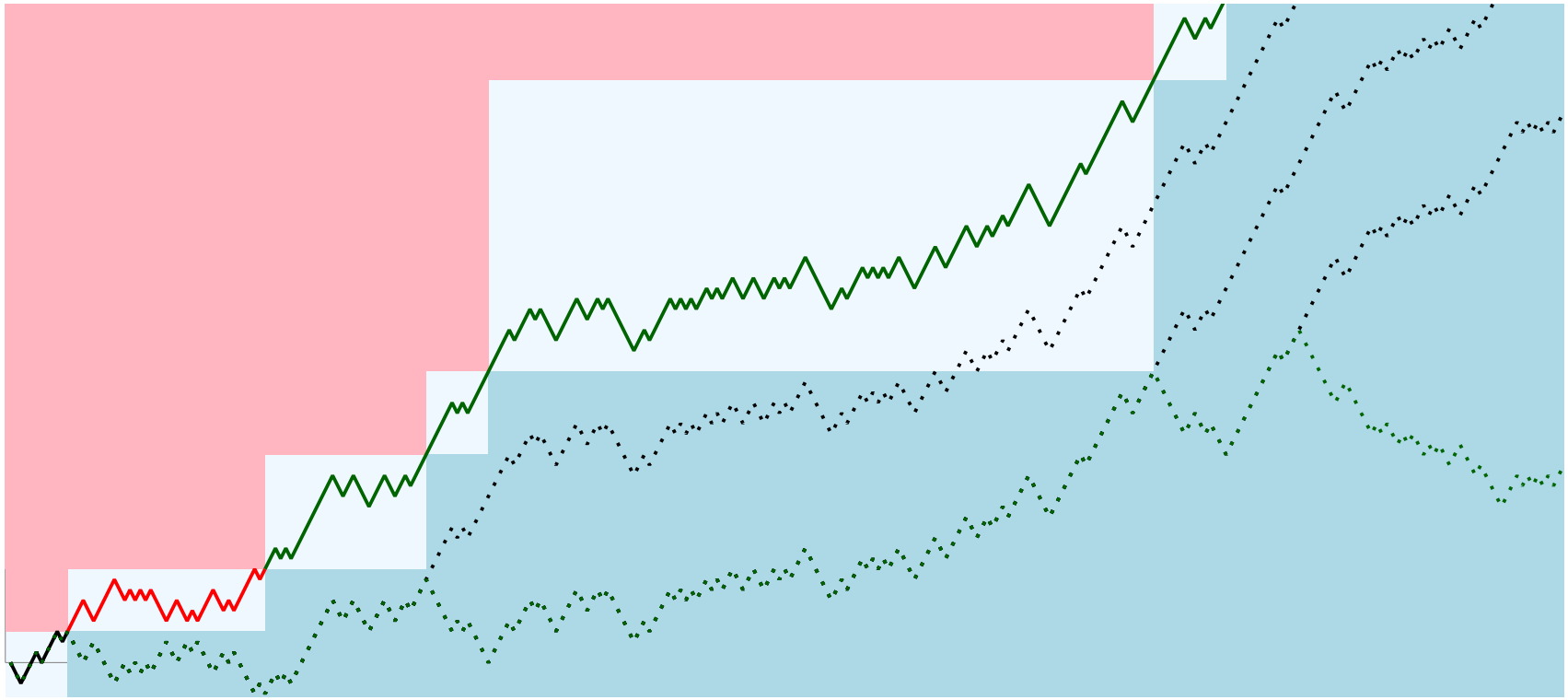
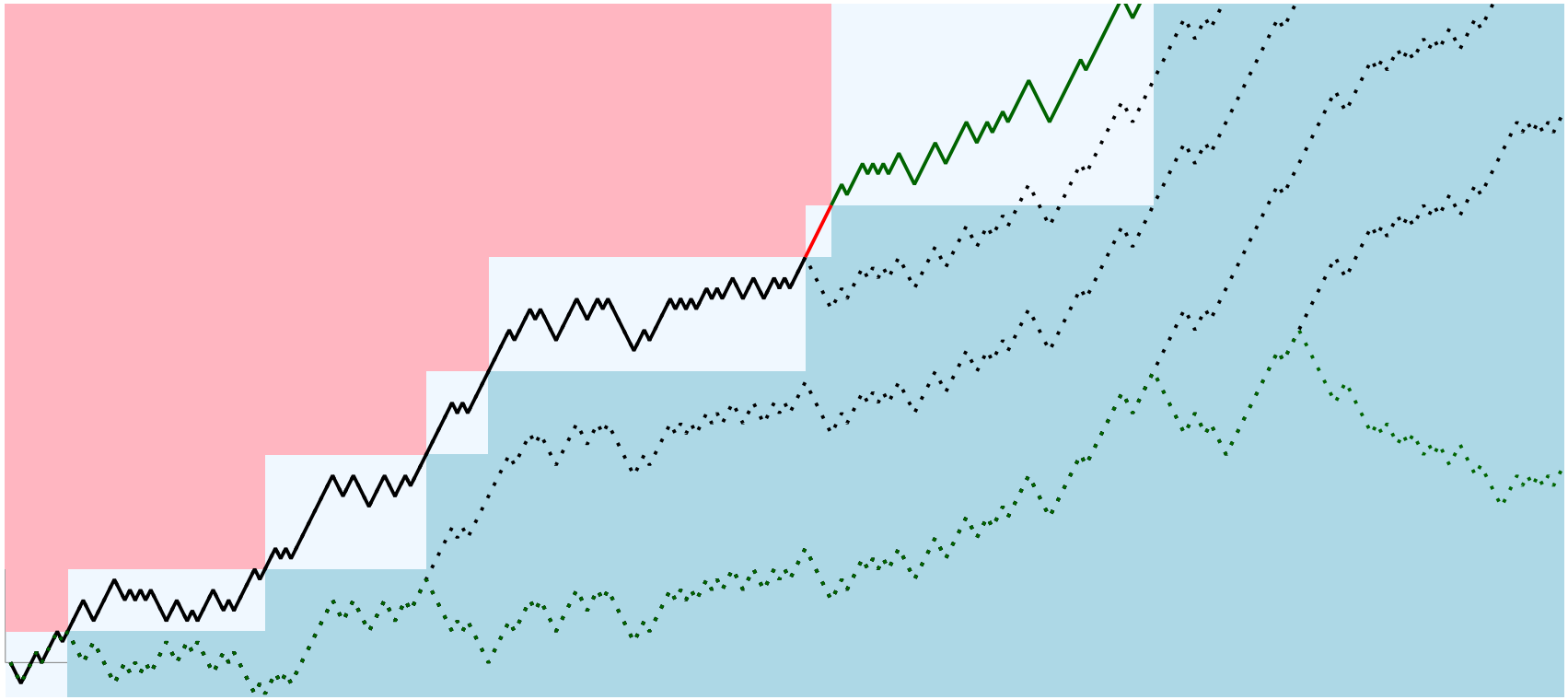


Figure 10: Effect of fourth unfold

5. Fifth maximal unfolding generates f_5.
   Here the unfolding procedure fragments a previous unfolding rectangle.



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- (All this occurs precisely in the case of polygonal f!)

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   - the sequence of unfold sizes is non-increasing and summable;
   - after the infinite sequence of unfolds is completed, only degenerate local maxima and minima can survive for the limit f_∞ (others will be employed and thus destroyed at various stages of construction of the sequence);

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- Exploit nesting to generate a martingale argument that $\dot{f}_n$ converges in L^1-norm to the constant function 1.
- Thus $f_n(x) \to x$ as $n \to \infty$.
- Re-write the roots x of $f_n(x) = y$ to give information about the point patterns determined as roots x of $f(x) = y$:

$$\mathbb{I}\{\text{ there is } x \in [0, L] \ : \ f_n(x) = y\}$$

can be unravelled to produce partial counts of the point patterns

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- Ignore reflection zones of f_n to approximate Variation (f): Banach's representation follows by monotone convergence.

Conclusion

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3. Alternate visual proof of Banach representation uses "monotonic runs" (peeling off successive layers of graph of f as viewed from the left);
4. It would be interesting to get a *direct* visual proof of the general Crofton formula (and – even more interesting – of the Poincaré kinematic formula).

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Project details

`git` version and branch

Version (branch):	v0.1.0.6 (`main`)
Committed by:	Wilfrid Kendall <W.S.Kendall@warwick.ac.uk>
Date:	Tue Mar 17 14:45:03 2026 +0000

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Previous versions of this talk

Summary of recent changes

Now moved to use `pdf` for figures.

To-do list

We now need to clarify the limiting behaviour of the f_n. Assuming an infinite sequence, we need to prove $\dot{f}_n \to 1$ both almost everywhere and in L^1. Consider these ideas:

- **Multiplication operators:** $\dot{f}_n = m_n \dot{f}_n$ where $m_n = \chi_n m_{n-1}$, for $\chi_n = 1 - 2 \times \mathbb{I}\{(u_n, v_n)\}$, where u_n, v_n form the basis for the nth unfold. Note that the open interval can be replaced indifferently by a closed or a half-open interval. This allows us to ignore the vertical shift (which is implied by the continuity requirement on f together with $f(0) = 0$).

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- Try to control the *sum* of all forthcoming unfolds.